“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 8

Talks with Rāmānanda Rāya

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 The ocean Gaura infused into the cloud — His devotee named Rāma — the nectars of the many conclusions of His own devotion; and when that cloud poured them out, the ocean itself became a treasury of jewels: the knowledge of those conclusions.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 As before, the Lord journeyed on, and after some days He came to the holy place of Jiyaḍa-Nṛsiṁha.

4 Seeing Nṛsiṁha, He fell prostrate before Him, and, absorbed in love, He danced, sang and offered many prayers.

5 “Śrī Nṛsiṁha! Glory to Nṛsiṁha! Glory, glory to Nṛsiṁha! Glory to the Lord of Prahlāda, the bee at the lotus of Padmā’s face!

6 “Fierce though He is, this Man-lion is not fierce to His own devotees — like a lion, gentle to its own cubs and fierce in its might to others.” (Śrīdhara Svāmī’s commentary on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 7.9.1)

7 Reciting many such verses, He offered His praise. Then a servant of Nṛsiṁha brought Him the Deity’s garland and prasāda.

8 As before, a certain brāhmaṇa invited Him. He stayed there that night and then went on.

9 Rising in the morning, the Lord walked on, absorbed in love, unaware, night and day, of any direction.

10 As before, He made Vaiṣṇavas of all the people, and after some days the Lord came to the bank of the Godāvarī.

11 Seeing the Godāvarī, He remembered the Yamunā; seeing the forest on its bank, He remembered Vṛndāvana.

12 He danced and sang in that forest for some time; then He crossed the Godāvarī and bathed there.

13 Leaving the bathing-place, He sat by the water some distance away and chanted the names of Kṛṣṇa.

14 Just then Rāmānanda Rāya arrived in a palanquin to bathe, with music playing.

15 Many Vedic brāhmaṇas came with him. He bathed and offered tarpaṇa and the other rites according to the rules.

16 Seeing him, the Lord knew: “This is Rāmānanda Rāya,” and His heart leapt up and ran out to meet him.

17 Still, the Lord kept His composure and remained seated. Seeing a wonderful sannyāsī, Rāmānanda came to Him.

18 His radiance was like that of a hundred suns, His garment the colour of dawn; His body was tall and beautifully formed, His eyes like lotuses.

19 Seeing Him, Rāmānanda was struck with wonder. He came forward and fell prostrate before Him.

20 The Lord rose and said, “Get up — say ‘Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!’” His heart longed to embrace him.

21 Still He asked, “Are you Rāya Rāmānanda?” He replied, “Yes, I am Your servant, a lowly śūdra.”

22 Then the Lord held him in a firm embrace, and, absorbed in love, Master and servant both lost consciousness.

23 The love natural to both of them awoke; embracing each other, they fell to the ground.

24 Stupor, sweat, tears, trembling, hair standing on end, change of colour — and from the lips of both came the name “Kṛṣṇa” in a faltering voice.

25 Seeing this, the brāhmaṇas were amazed, and all those Vedic brāhmaṇas began to reason among themselves:

26 “We see that this sannyāsī’s splendour is like that of Brahman. Why does He weep, embracing a śūdra?

27 And this mahārāja is a great scholar and a grave man, yet at the touch of this sannyāsī he has become maddened and lost all composure.”

28 So the brāhmaṇas reflected within themselves. Seeing people who were strangers to such feelings, the Lord restrained Himself.

29 Growing calm, the two sat down on that spot, and Mahāprabhu, smiling, began to speak.

30 “Sārvabhauma Bhaṭṭācārya told Me of your virtues and earnestly urged Me to meet you.

31 It was to meet you that I came here, and how good it is that I have found you without any effort!”

32 Rāya said, “Sārvabhauma regards me as his servant; even in my absence he is careful of my welfare.

33 By his mercy I have obtained Your sight; today my human birth has borne its fruit.

34 Your mercy to Sārvabhauma is plain from this: yielding to his love, You have touched an untouchable.

35 Where are You — the Lord Nārāyaṇa Himself — and where am I — a servant of the king, a worldly man, the lowest of śūdras?

36 You did not shrink from touching me, nor did You fear the Vedas, though the Vedas forbid You even to see me.

37 Your mercy makes You do what is condemned. You are the Lord Himself — who can know Your heart?

38 You have come here to deliver me. You are supremely compassionate, the purifier of the fallen.

39 This is the nature of great souls: to deliver the wretched. Though they have no business of their own, they still go to their houses.

40 “O lord, when great souls come to people — to householders of poor understanding — it is for nothing else than their highest good.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.8.4)

41 About a thousand people have come with me, brāhmaṇas and others, and at the sight of You all their hearts have melted.

42 I hear the names “Kṛṣṇa” and “Hari” on everyone’s lips; the hair of all stands on end, and their eyes are filled with tears.

43 In form and in nature You bear the marks of the Lord. Such transcendental qualities are not possible in a jīva.”

44 The Lord said, “You are the best of the great devotees (*mahā-bhāgavata*); it is at the sight of you that all their hearts have melted.

45 What to speak of others — I am a Māyāvādī sannyāsī, yet even I float in love for Kṛṣṇa at your touch.

46 Knowing this, Sārvabhauma told Me to meet you, so that My hard heart might be purified.”

47 So the two praised each other’s virtues, their hearts rejoicing at the sight of each other.

48 Just then a Vedic brāhmaṇa, a Vaiṣṇava, bowed down to the Lord and invited Him for a meal.

49 Knowing him to be a Vaiṣṇava, the Lord accepted his invitation; then, smiling slightly, He said to Rāmānanda:

50 “I long to hear talks about Kṛṣṇa from your lips. May I see you again!”

51 Rāya said, “If You have come to purify a wretch like me, my wicked heart will not become pure merely by seeing You.

52 Stay five or seven days and cleanse it; then this wicked mind of mine will become pure."

53 Though neither could bear the separation, Rāmānanda Rāya bowed down and took his leave.

54 The Lord went to that brāhmaṇa's house and took His meal there; and while both were eagerly waiting, evening came.

55 The Lord had bathed and performed His evening duties and was sitting, when Rāya came with a single servant to meet Him.

56 Rāya bowed down, the Lord embraced him, and there the two began to speak about Kṛṣṇa.

57 The Lord said, "Recite a verse that determines the goal (*sādhya*)." Rāya said, "By following one's own *dharma*, devotion to Viṣṇu arises.

58 "The Supreme Person, Viṣṇu, is worshipped by a person who keeps the conduct of *varṇa* and *āśrama*. There is no other path to please Him." (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 3.8.9)

59 The Lord said, "This is external. Go further." Rāya said, "The essence of all goals is to offer one's actions to Kṛṣṇa.

60 "Whatever you do, whatever you eat, whatever you offer in sacrifice, whatever you give away and whatever austerity you perform, O son of Kuntī, do it as an offering to Me." (Bhagavad-gītā, 9.27)

61 The Lord said, "This is external. Go further." Rāya said, "Giving up one's own *dharma* — this is the essence of the goal.

62 “Knowing in this way their merits and faults, he who gives up all his duties, even those I Myself have enjoined, and worships Me — he is the best of men.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.11.32)

63 “Give up all *dharmas* and take shelter of Me alone. I shall free you from all sins; do not grieve.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.66)

64 The Lord said, “This is external. Go further.” Rāya said, “Devotion mixed with knowledge is the essence of the goal.

65 “One who has realized Brahman and is serene within neither grieves nor desires. Equal to all beings, he attains supreme devotion to Me.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.54)

66 The Lord said, “This is external. Go further.” Rāya said, “Devotion free from (the endeavour for) knowledge is the essence of the goal.

67 “Those who give up the endeavour for knowledge and simply bow down, living by the accounts of You spoken by the saintly — who, remaining where they are, take these accounts into their ears and honour them with body, speech and mind — by them You, O Unconquerable One, are in fact conquered within the three worlds.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.3)

68 The Lord said, “This is so, but go further.” Rāya said, “Loving devotion (*prema-bhakti*) is the essence of all goals.

69 “The Friend of the afflicted may be worshipped with many offerings, but only love makes the devotee’s heart melt with joy — just as food and drink give pleasure only so long as there is hunger in the stomach and burning thirst.” (Padyāvalī, 13)

70 “A mind imbued with the *rasa* of devotion to Kṛṣṇa — buy it, if it can be found anywhere! Its only price is eagerness (*laulya*); it cannot be obtained by the pious deeds of ten million births.” (Padyāvalī, 14)

71 The Lord said, “This is so, but go further.” Rāya said, “Love in servitude (*dāsya-prema*) is the essence of all goals.

72 “A person becomes pure merely by hearing His name. What, then, remains to be attained by the servants of Him whose feet are holy places?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.5.16)

73 “When, O Lord, serving You alone without cease, with every other desire completely stilled, shall I live as Your wholly devoted eternal servant and fill my life with joy?” (Stotra-ratna, 43)

74 The Lord said, “This is so; go a little further.” Rāya said, “Love in friendship (*sakhya-prema*) is the essence of all goals.

75 “Thus with Him — to the sages the experience of the bliss of Brahman, to those who have taken up His service the Supreme Deity, and to those under the spell of *māyā* a human boy — the cowherd boys played, for they had amassed heaps of pious deeds.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.12.11)

76 The Lord said, “This is excellent, but go further.” Rāya said, “Parental love (*vātsalya-prema*) is the essence of all goals.

77 “O brāhmaṇa, what good deed did Nanda perform to win such great fortune? And what did the most fortunate Yaśodā do, that Hari Himself drank from her breast?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.8.46)

78 “Neither Brahmā, nor Śiva, nor even Śrī, who rests on His breast, obtained the mercy that the cowherd woman (Yaśodā) received from the Giver of liberation.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.9.20)

79 The Lord said, “This is excellent, but go further.” Rāya said, “The love of the beloved for her Lover (*kānta-bhāva*) is the essence of the goal that is *prema*.

80 “The grace that came to the beauties of Vraja in the festival of the *rāsa*, when they received the blessing of His mighty arms about their necks, was never given even to Śrī, who rests on His breast in utmost devotion, nor to the women of heaven, fragrant and lustrous as lotuses — what then to speak of others?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.47.60)

81 “Among them appeared Śauri (Kṛṣṇa), His lotus face smiling, wearing yellow garments and a garland — the very enchanter of Cupid.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.32.2)

82 There are many means of attaining Kṛṣṇa, and many degrees in attaining Him.

83 But whatever *rasa* a devotee has is for him the best. Yet when one considers impartially, there are higher and higher degrees.

84 “Although love (*rati*), rising from one kind to the next, is ever richer in delight, by the inclination of the heart one particular kind seems sweetest to a particular devotee.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.5.38)

85 The qualities of each preceding *rasa* are present in the one that follows; counting one, two and so on, they increase up to five.

86 As the qualities increase, the taste increases in each *rasa*; and the qualities of *śānta*, *dāsya*, *sakhya* and *vātsalya* all dwell in *mādhurya*.

87 It is as with the qualities of ether and the other elements: in each following element they increase — two, three — until earth has all five.

88 Kṛṣṇa is attained completely through this *prema*. Kṛṣṇa is under the control of this *prema* — so the Bhāgavata says:

89 “Devotion to Me brings living beings to immortality. And how fortunate you are to have the love that brings you to Me!” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.82.44)

90 Kṛṣṇa has a firm promise that holds for all time: as one worships Him, so does He reciprocate.

91 But He cannot reciprocate this *prema* in equal measure, and so He becomes a debtor — so the Bhāgavata says:

92 “O gopīs, your union with Me is faultless. Even in a lifetime of the gods I could not repay you for what you have done: you cut the fetters of home, so hard to break, and came to Me. So let your own good deed be your reward.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.32.22)

93 Although Kṛṣṇa’s beauty is the summit of sweetness, in the company of the goddesses of Vraja His sweetness increases still more.

94 “There, with them, Bhagavān, the son of Devakī, shone exceedingly, like a great emerald among golden gems.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.33.6)

95 The Lord said, “This is certainly the limit of the goal. But be kind and tell Me if there is anything beyond.”

96 Rāya said, “Until now I did not know that there was anyone in the world who would ask beyond this.

97 Among these (forms of love), Rādhā’s love is the crest-jewel of all goals; its glory is proclaimed in all the scriptures.

98 “As Rādhā is dear to Viṣṇu, so is Her pond dear to Him; among all the gopīs She alone is His most beloved.” (Padma Purāṇa; Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, Uttara-khaṇḍa, 45)

99 “Surely the Lord, Bhagavān Hari, has been worshipped by Her, for Govinda, pleased, has left us and led Her away to a secluded place.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.30.28)

100 The Lord said, “Go on — I am happy to hear you. A river of wondrous nectar flows from your lips.

101 Fearing the other gopīs, He stole Rādhā away; for when there is regard for others, the depth of love does not show itself.

102 If for Rādhā’s sake He openly abandons the other gopīs, then we know how deeply Kṛṣṇa is attached to Rādhā.”

103 Rāya said, “Then hear the glory of that love. In the three worlds there is nothing to compare with Rādhā’s love.

104 Leaving the circle of the gopīs’ *rāsa* dance, He wanders through the forest in search of Rādhā, lamenting.

105 “Placing Rādhā in His heart — the chain that bound His desire for the very essence of the *rāsa* — Kṛṣṇa, the enemy of Kaṁsa, left the other beauties of Vraja.” (Gīta-govinda, 3.1)

106 “Searching here and there for Rādhikā, His mind wearied by the wounds of Ananga’s arrows and filled with remorse, Mādhava sank down in despair in a grove on the edge of the Yamunā’s bank.” (Gīta-govinda, 3.2)

107 If one considers the meaning of these two verses, one understands; as one considers them, it is as if a mine of nectar opens up.

108 In the *rāsa* pastime with hundreds of millions of gopīs, He stays at Rādhā's side in one of His forms.

109 In ordinary love one sees equality everywhere; but in Rādhā's crooked love there arose contrariness (*vāmatā*).

110 "Like the movement of a snake, the course of love is crooked by nature. Therefore pique (*māna*) arises between the young lovers, with cause and without cause." (Ujjvala-nīlamaṇi, Śṛṅgāra-bheda-kathana, 102)

111 In anger and pique She left the *rāsa*, and Śrī Hari, not seeing Her, became distressed.

112 Kṛṣṇa's complete desire is the *rāsa-līlā*, and in that desire for the *rāsa-līlā* Rādhikā is the chain that binds it.

113 Without Her the *rāsa-līlā* did not please His heart, so He left the circle and went to look for Rādhā.

114 Wandering here and there and finding Rādhā nowhere, He fell into despair, wearied by the arrows of the god of love (Kāma).

115 Even hundreds of millions of gopīs could not quench His desire. From this we can infer the qualities of Śrī Rādhikā."

116 The Lord said, "All the truths for which I came to you have now become known to Me.

117 Now I know who is to be served and by what means. Yet there is something more beyond, and I wish to hear it.

118 Tell Me the true nature of Kṛṣṇa and the true nature of Rādhā; what truth *rasa* is, and of what truth *prema* is the form.

119 Be kind and tell Me these truths: no one but you can explain them.”

120 Rāya said, “I know nothing of this. I speak only the words You make me speak.

121 I repeat Your teaching like a parrot reciting its lesson. You are the Lord Himself — who can understand Your play?

122 You inspire my heart and make my tongue speak the words; I do not know at all whether what I say is good or bad.”

123 The Lord said, “I am a Māyāvādī sannyāsī. I do not know the truth of *bhakti*; I am adrift in Māyāvāda.

124 In Sārvabhauma’s company My mind became pure, and I asked him, ‘Tell Me the truth of devotion to Kṛṣṇa.’

125 He said, ‘I do not know the talks about Kṛṣṇa. Only Rāmānanda knows them, and he is not here.’

126 Hearing of your glory, I came to you — and you praise Me, thinking of Me as a sannyāsī.

127 Whether one is a *vipra*, a *sannyāsī* or a *śūdra* — whoever knows the truth of Kṛṣṇa is a guru.

128 Do not deceive Me by treating Me as a sannyāsī. Tell Me the truth of Kṛṣṇa and Rādhā and fulfil My heart’s desire.”

129 Rāya was full of *prema*, a great devotee; Kṛṣṇa's *māyā* could not cover his mind.

130 Yet the Lord's will is supremely powerful, and, though he knew the truth, Rāya's mind began to waver.

131 Rāya said, "I am a dancer, and You are the master of the stage (*sūtra-dhāra*): as You make me dance, so I wish to dance.

132 My tongue is a *vīṇā*, and You are the one who plays it: whatever rises in Your mind, that alone I utter.

133 Kṛṣṇa is the Supreme Lord, Bhagavān Himself, the source of all *avatāras* and the foremost cause of all causes.

134 Endless are the Vaikuṇṭhas, endless the *avatāras* and endless the universes, and He is the support of them all.

135 His body is eternal being, knowledge and bliss; He is the son of the king of Vraja, full of all majesty, all potencies and all *rasas*.

136 "Kṛṣṇa, Govinda, is the Supreme Lord; His form is eternal being, knowledge and bliss. He has no beginning, yet He is the beginning of all, the cause of all causes." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.1)

137 In Vṛndāvana He is the transcendental, ever-new Madana, worshipped with the Kāma-gāyatrī and the Kāma-bīja.

138 He draws the hearts of all — men and women, the moving and the unmoving; He is the very enchanter of Cupid.

139 "Among them appeared Śauri (Kṛṣṇa), His lotus face smiling, wearing yellow garments and a garland — the very enchanter of Cupid." (Śrīmad-

Bhāgavatam, 10.32.2)

140 The nectar of *rasa* of various devotees is of many kinds; of all those nectars of *rasa* He is the object (*viṣaya*), and the devotee the abode (*āśraya*).

141 “Glory to the Moon, the embodiment of the nectar of all *rasas*, who with His spreading radiance has subdued Tārakā and Pāli, who has won Śyāmā and Lalitā, and who is dearest to Rādhā!” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.1.1)

142 He bears a form made of *śṛṅgāra*, the king of *rasas*; therefore He steals all hearts, even His own.

143 “O friend, see how Hari sports in spring! Delighting all and giving them bliss, with limbs dark and tender as a row of blue lotuses He brings a festival to the god of love; freely embraced on every side by the beauties of Vraja, He is, as it were, *śṛṅgāra* embodied, enchanted Himself.” (Gīta-govinda, 1.11)

144 He steals the minds of *avatāras* such as the Lord of Lakṣmī, and He attracts women such as Lakṣmī.

145 “I brought the brāhmaṇa’s sons here because I wished to see you two, who have descended to earth as My portions for the protection of *dharma*. When you have slain the *asuras*, the burden of the earth, hurry back to Me here.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.89.58)

146 “O Lord, we do not know by what merit he has earned the right to touch the dust of Your feet — that dust for which Śrī, the best of women, longing for it, gave up all desires and practised austerities for so long, keeping her vows.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.16.36)

147 His own sweetness steals His own mind, and He longs to embrace Himself.

148 “What wondrous flood of My sweetness, never known before and surpassing all, appears here! Alas, seeing it, even I long with an eager heart to enjoy it, as Rādhikā does.” (Lalita-mādhava, 8.34)

149 Thus I have told you briefly of Kṛṣṇa’s true nature. Now hear, briefly, the truth of Rādhā.

150 Kṛṣṇa’s potencies are endless, and among them three are chief: the spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*), the potency of *māyā* (*māyā-śakti*) and the potency of the *jīvas* (*jīva-śakti*).

151 They are called the internal, the external and the marginal; the internal, His own potency (*svarūpa-śakti*), is above all.

152 “The potency of Viṣṇu is declared to be superior; the potency called the knower of the field (*kṣetrajña*) is likewise superior; and the other, called ignorance and karma, is held to be a third potency.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 6.7.61)

153 Kṛṣṇa’s nature is made of eternal being, knowledge and bliss; therefore His own potency has three forms.

154 In the aspect of bliss She is Hlādinī, in the aspect of being Sandhinī, and in the aspect of consciousness Samvit, which we know as knowledge.

155 “O Lord, You are the shelter of all, and in You Hlādinī, Sandhinī and Samvit are one potency. But that which causes joy, pain and a mixture of the two is not in You, for You are beyond the *guṇas*.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 1.12.69)

156 Because she gladdens Kṛṣṇa, her name is Hlādinī; through that potency He Himself tastes happiness.

157 Kṛṣṇa, happiness itself, relishes happiness, and *hlādinī* is the cause of the happiness He gives His devotees.

158 The essential part of *hlādinī* is called *prema*. It bears the name of *rasa*, whose form is spiritual bliss.

159 The highest essence of *prema* is known as *mahābhāva*, and Rādhā Ṭhākurāṇī is that *mahābhāva* embodied.

160 “Of the two, Rādhikā is superior in every way. She is the embodiment of *mahābhāva*, and in virtues She surpasses all.” (Ujjvala-nīlamaṇi, 4.3)

161 Her body is the very form of *prema*, steeped in *prema*, and the world knows Her as the foremost of Kṛṣṇa’s beloveds.

162 “I worship Govinda, the original Person, the Soul of all. He dwells eternally in Goloka with the gopīs, His potencies (*kalās*), who are one with Him in nature and imbued with blissful spiritual rasa.” (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.37)

163 That *mahābhāva* is the essence of *cintāmaṇi*, the wish-fulfilling gem. Her work is to fulfill Kṛṣṇa’s desires.

164 Rādhā’s own nature is the *cintāmaṇi* of *mahābhāva*, and Lalitā and the other *sakhīs* are expansions of Her body (*kāya-vyūha*).

165 Kṛṣṇa’s affection (*sneha*) for Rādhā is the fragrant unguent, and by it Her body is fragrant and radiant in complexion.

166 Her first bath is in the stream of the nectar of compassion, the next in the stream of the nectar of youth.

167 After that She bathes in the stream of the nectar of loveliness (*lāvaṇya*) and puts on Her own modesty as a dark silk sari.

168 Her *anurāga* for Kṛṣṇa is Her second garment, rose-red, and Her breast is covered by the bodice of *praṇaya* and *māna*.

169 Her beauty is *kuṅkuma*, the love of Her *sakhīs* is sandal paste, and the luster of Her smile is camphor; these three anoint Her limbs.

170 Kṛṣṇa's *ujjvala-rasa* is abundant musk, and Her body is painted with that musk.

171 Her concealed *māna* and contrariness (*vāmya*) are the arrangement of Her hair, and Her nature as *dhīrādhīrā*, at once composed and impetuous, is the silk wrap on Her body.

172 Her lips shine with the red of the betel of *rāga*, and the crookedness of *prema* is the kohl on Her eyes.

173 The *sūddīpta sāttvika bhāvas* and the *sañcārī bhāvas*, beginning with joy — all these *bhāvas* are ornaments filling Her every limb.

174 She is adorned with the twenty *bhāvas*, beginning with *kila-kiñcita*, and the flower garland of Her many virtues covers Her whole body.

175 The *tilaka* of good fortune shines on Her lovely forehead. *Prema-vaicittya* — the dread of separation that love feels even in the Beloved's presence — is the jewel, and Her heart is the pendant.

176 Her budding youth (*madhya-vayasa*) is Her hand resting on a friend's shoulder, and Her thoughts of Kṛṣṇa's pastimes are the *sakhīs* all around Her.

177 In the chamber of Her own bodily fragrance stands the couch of pride. Seated on it, She always thinks of being with Kṛṣṇa.

178 Kṛṣṇa's name, qualities and fame are the ornaments in Her ears, and a flood of Kṛṣṇa's name, qualities and fame pours forth in Her speech.

179 She makes Kṛṣṇa drink the honey of *śyāma-rasa*, and She constantly fulfills all His desires.

180 She is the mine of the jewel of pure love for Kṛṣṇa, and Her body is filled with a host of matchless virtues.

181 "Who is the birthplace of Kṛṣṇa's love? Śrīmatī Rādhikā alone. Who is His beloved of matchless virtues? Rādhikā alone, and no other. Crookedness in Her hair, restlessness in Her eyes, firmness in Her breasts — Rādhikā alone, and no other, is able to fulfill Hari's desires." (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 11.122)

182 Satyabhāmā longs for Her good fortune, and the women of Vraja learn the graceful arts from Her.

183 Lakṣmī and Pārvatī long for Her beauty and other virtues, and Arundhatī longs for Her steadfast fidelity (*pativratā-dharma*).

184 Even Kṛṣṇa finds no end in counting Her virtues; how then could an insignificant *jīva* count them?"

185 The Lord said, "I have understood the truth of the love of Kṛṣṇa and Rādhā. Now I wish to hear of the greatness of Their pastimes."

186 Rāya said, “Kṛṣṇa is *dhīra-lalita*, the carefree and playful hero, whose nature is ceaseless love-play (*kāma-krīḍā*).

187 “Clever, ever fresh in youth, expert in jesting and free from care, and generally controlled by His beloveds — such is the *dhīra-lalita* hero.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.230)

188 Day and night He plays with Rādhā in the bowers, and in that joyful play He made His youth fruitful.

189 “By words that hinted boldly at the arts of love of the night before, He made Rādhikā close Her eyes in shyness before Her friends; then, drawing playful *makarīs* on Her breasts, He showed the utmost skill. So Hari, sporting in the bowers, makes His youth fruitful.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.231)”

190 The Lord said, “This is so, but go further and tell Me more.” Rāya said, “Beyond this my understanding does not reach.

191 There is one thing more, called *prema-vilāsa-vivarta*. Will hearing of it make You happy, or not?”

192 Saying this, he sang a song of his own composition, and the Lord, overwhelmed with love, covered Rāya’s mouth with His own hand.

193 “From the very first, love (*rāga*) arose from the play of our eyes. Day by day it grew and knew no bound. He was not the lover, nor was I the beloved: Manobhava, the god of love, ground our two hearts into one. O friend, if you find that He has forgotten, tell Kānu all these stories of our love. We sought no messenger and asked no one else: when we met, the five arrows were our go-between. Now that very *rāga* has become *virāga*, the pain of separation, and you have become the messenger. Such is the way of love for an excellent hero.”

194 “O lord of elephants who sport in the bowers of the hill! The artist skilled in *śṛṅgāra* gradually melted the lac of Rādhā’s heart and of Yours with the sweat of ecstasy and joined them, so that the illusion of difference vanished. Then, here within the palace of the universe, he himself colored them, for wonder, with abundant vermilion of fresh *rāga*.” (Ujjvala-nīlamaṇi, 14.155)

195 The Lord said, “This is the limit of the goal (*sādhya-vastu*). By your grace I have come to know it for certain.

196 No one attains the goal without *sādhana*. Be kind, Rāya, and tell Me the means of attaining it.”

197 Rāya said, “Whatever You make me say, those are the words I speak. Whether what I say is good or bad, I do not know at all.

198 Who in the three worlds is so steady that he can stay firm in the drama staged by Your power (*māyā*)?

199 You are the speaker through my mouth, and You are also the listener. Now hear the account of *sādhana*, which is most secret.

200 These pastimes of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa are deeply hidden. They cannot be perceived in the moods of servitude, parental love and the rest.

201 Only the *sakhīs* have the right of entry here, and from the *sakhīs* comes the unfolding of these pastimes.

202 Without the *sakhīs* these pastimes are not nourished. The *sakhīs* unfold the pastimes, and the *sakhīs* relish them.

203–204 Without the *sakhīs*, no one else has access to these pastimes. One who follows them in the mood of a *sakhī* attains the goal: service to

Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa in the bowers. To attain that goal there is no other means.

205 “Though the love (*bhāva*) of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa is boundless, happiness itself and self-manifest, without Their own *sakhīs* it never for a moment carries the fullness of *rasa*, just as the Lord does not without His spiritual opulences. What knower of *rasa*, then, would not take shelter at the feet of these *sakhīs*?” (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 10.17)

206 The *sakhīs* have one nature that words cannot describe: they have no wish for pastimes of their own with Kṛṣṇa.

207 By arranging Rādhikā’s pastimes with Kṛṣṇa they find happiness ten million times greater than their own.

208 Rādhā’s own nature is the wish-fulfilling creeper of love for Kṛṣṇa, and the *sakhīs* are its shoots, flowers and leaves.

209 When the nectar of Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes waters the creeper, the shoots and the rest feel ten million times more happiness than if they themselves were watered.

210 “The *sakhīs* of Śrī Rādhikā are equal to Her. Rādhikā is *hlādinī*, the potency of Kṛṣṇa, the moon who delights the lilies of Vraja, and the *sakhīs* are like the shoots, leaves and flowers of Her creeper of *prema*, the essence of that potency. When She is watered with floods of the nectarean *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes and rejoices, they become a hundred times more joyful than if they themselves were watered — and in this there is nothing to wonder at.” (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 10.16)

211 Although the *sakhīs* have no wish to meet Kṛṣṇa for themselves, Rādhikā takes pains to arrange their meeting with Him.

212 Under various pretexts She sends them to Kṛṣṇa and arranges their meeting, and from this She finds ten million times more happiness than from Her own meeting with Him.

213 With pure love for one another they nourish the *rasa*, and Kṛṣṇa is delighted to see their love.

214 The natural love of the gopīs is not worldly *kāma*. It is called "*kāma*" only because it resembles the play of *kāma*.

215 "It is the prema of the cowherd women that became famed under the name *kāma*; and so even Uddhava and others dear to the Lord long for it." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.285)

216 The aim of *kāma* is the pleasure of one's own senses, but the aim of the gopīs' supreme love is Kṛṣṇa's happiness.

217 The gopīs have no desire for the pleasure of their own senses. They join Kṛṣṇa in the play of union only to give Him happiness.

218 "O dear one, Your tender lotus feet we place gently on our hard breasts, afraid to hurt them — and with those feet You wander through the forest! Are they not hurt by the sharp pebbles? You are our very life, and our minds are reeling." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.31.19)

219 One who longs for the nectar of that mood of the gopīs gives up Vedic *dharma* and worships Kṛṣṇa.

220 One who worships Him on the path of *rāgānugā* attains in Vraja the son of the king of Vraja.

221 Whoever worships taking up the mood of one of the people of Vraja receives a body suited to that mood and attains Kṛṣṇa in Vraja.

222 The example of this is the Śrutis of the Upaniṣads: worshiping on the path of *rāga*, they attained the son of the king of Vraja.

223 “The sages who have restrained breath, mind and senses and are firmly fixed in yoga worship in their hearts that Truth which even Your enemies attained by remembering You. The women, whose minds clung to Your mighty arms, like the coils of the king of serpents, attained the nectar of Your lotus feet; and we too, becoming like them and sharing their vision, attained that nectar of Your lotus feet.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.87.23)

224 The word *sama-dṛśaḥ* means “following that mood,” and the word *samāḥ* means that the Śrutis attained the bodies of gopīs.

225 The phrase *aṅghri-padma-sudhā* means the bliss of Kṛṣṇa’s company. On the path of rules (*vidhi-mārga*) one does not attain Kṛṣṇacandra in Vraja.

226 “Bhagavān, the son of the gopī, is not so easily attained by the embodied, nor by the *jñānīs* who have become one with the self, as He is here by those who have *bhakti*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.9.21)

227 Therefore, accepting the mood of the gopīs, one thinks night and day of the pastimes of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa.

228 Meditating in one’s perfected spiritual body (*siddha-deha*), one serves there, and in the mood of a *sakhī* one attains the feet of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa.

229 Without following the gopīs, one who worships with awareness of His majesty (*aiśvarya*) does not attain the son of the king of Vraja.

230 The example of this is Lakṣmī: she performed worship, yet she did not attain the son of the king of Vraja in Vraja.

231 “Not even Śrī, who dwells on His chest and loves Him most intimately, received such grace, nor did the heavenly maidens with the fragrance and luster of lotuses — what then of other women? Such was the grace that came to the beauties of Vraja when, in the festival of the *rāsa*, His arms embraced their necks and their hopes were fulfilled.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.47.60)”

232 Hearing this, the Lord embraced him, and the two of them wept, their arms around each other’s necks.

233 In this way they spent the night absorbed in love, and in the morning both went about their own duties.

234 At the time of parting, Rāmānanda Rāya clasped the Lord’s feet and humbly entreated Him:

235 “You have come here to show me mercy. Stay ten days and purify my wicked mind.

236 There is no one but You to deliver the *jīvas*, no one but You to give love for Kṛṣṇa.”

237 The Lord said, “I came because I had heard of your virtues — to purify My mind by hearing talks of Kṛṣṇa.

238 Your greatness is just as I heard. You are the utmost limit in knowing the *rasa* of the love of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa.

239 What to speak of ten days? As long as I live, I shall never be able to give you up.

240 You and I shall live together in Nīlācala and happily pass our time in the joy of talks about Kṛṣṇa.”

241 Saying this, both went about their own duties, and in the evening Rāya came again and met the Lord.

242 Meeting together, the two sat in seclusion and joyfully held a discussion of questions and answers.

243 The Lord asked and Rāmānanda answered; in this way they talked together that night.

244 The Lord asked, “Of all kinds of knowledge, which is the best?” Rāya answered, “There is no knowledge other than devotion to Kṛṣṇa.”

245 “Of all kinds of fame, which is the greatest for a *jīva*?” “The fame of one who is known as a devotee of Kṛṣṇa.”

246 “Among all riches, which should we count as a *jīva*’s true wealth?” “One who has love for Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa is the richest of all.”

247 “Of all sorrows, which is the heaviest?” “I see no sorrow but separation from a devotee of Kṛṣṇa.”

248 “Among the liberated, which *jīva* should we regard as truly liberated?” “One who has love for Kṛṣṇa is the crown jewel of the liberated.”

249 “Among songs, which song is the *jīva*’s own *dharma*?” “The song whose heart is the loving play of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa.”

250 “Among all that is good, what is the highest good for a *jīva*?” “There is no good other than the company of Kṛṣṇa’s devotees.”

251 “Whom should a *jīva* remember at every moment?” “Remembering Kṛṣṇa’s name, qualities and pastimes is the chief remembrance.”

252 “Among all objects of meditation, on what should a *jīva* meditate?” “Meditation on the lotus feet of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa is the chief.”

253 “Giving up everything, where should a *jīva* live?” “In the land of Śrī Vṛndāvana, where the *rāsa* pastime goes on eternally.”

254 “Of all things to hear, what is best for a *jīva* to hear?” “The pastimes of the love of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa, an elixir for the ears.”

255 “Of all objects of worship, which is the chief?” “The best object of worship is the name of the Divine Couple, ‘Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa.’”

256 “Those who desire liberation and those who desire enjoyment — where do the two of them go?” “They end up in an immobile body and in the body of a god.

257 The crow that knows no taste sucks the bitter nimba fruit of *jñāna*, while the cuckoo that knows *rasa* eats the mango buds of *prema*.

258 The unfortunate *jñānī* tastes dry knowledge, while the fortunate one drinks the nectar of love for Kṛṣṇa.”

259 In this way the two of them, immersed in the *rasa* of talks about Kṛṣṇa, danced, sang and wept until the night came to an end.

260 In the morning both went about their duties, and the next day, in the evening, Rāya came and met the Lord again.

261 After they had talked intimately of Kṛṣṇa for some time, Rāya clasped the Lord’s feet and made an appeal:

262 “The truth of Kṛṣṇa, the truth of Rādhā, the essence of the truth of *prema*, the truth of *rasa*, the truth of *līlā* in all its variety —

263 all these truths You have revealed in my heart, just as Nārāyaṇa taught the Veda to Brahmā.

264 Such is the way of the Lord who dwells within: He does not speak outwardly, but reveals the truth in the heart.

265 “Let us meditate on the Supreme Truth, from whom the birth and so on of this universe proceed, directly and indirectly; who is fully aware of all purposes and shines by Himself (*svarāṭ*); who revealed the Veda through the heart to the first poet, Brahmā; about whom even the wise are bewildered; in whom, as fire, water and earth pass into one another, the threefold creation is real; and who by His own power is ever free of all deception.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.1)

266 Yet one doubt remains in my heart. Be merciful and resolve it for me.

267 At first I saw You in the form of a *sannyāsī*, but now I see You as a dark cowherd boy.

268 Before You I see a golden doll, and her golden luster covers Your whole body.

269 Within it I clearly see Your face with the flute, and Your lotus eyes restless with many moods.

270 Seeing You like this fills me with wonder. Tell me frankly, Prabhu, what is the cause of it?”

271 The Lord said, “You have deep love for Kṛṣṇa, and know for certain that this is the nature of love.

272 The *mahā-bhāgavata* sees moving and unmoving things, and wherever he looks, Śrī Kṛṣṇa appears to him.

273 He sees moving and unmoving things, yet he does not see their forms: everywhere his worshipful Lord (*iṣṭa-deva*) appears to him.

274 “One who sees in all beings his own love for the Lord (*bhagavad-bhāva*), and sees all beings in the Lord, the Self of all, is the best of devotees (*bhāgavatottama*).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.45)

275 “The forest creepers and trees, rich with flowers and fruits, their branches bowed with the weight and their bodies thrilled with love, poured down streams of honey, as if revealing Viṣṇu within themselves.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.35.9)

276 You have great love for Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa, and so Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa appear to you wherever you look.”

277 Rāya said, “Prabhu, give up this grand pretence. Do not hide Your own form from me.

278 Accepting the mood and luster of Rādhikā, You have descended to taste Your own *rasa*.

279 Your own secret purpose is to taste *prema*, and in passing You have filled the three worlds with *prema*.

280 You Yourself came to deliver me, and now You are deceiving me. What kind of behavior is this?”

281 Then, smiling, the Lord showed him His own form: Rasarāja and Mahābhāva, the two in one form.

282 Seeing this, Rāmānanda fainted in bliss. Unable to hold himself up, he fell to the ground.

283 The Lord touched him with His hand and brought him back to consciousness, and seeing Him in the dress of a *sannyāsī*, Rāya was astonished.

284 Embracing him, the Lord comforted him: “No one but you sees this form.

285 The truth of Me, My pastimes and My *rasa* are within your perception; therefore I have shown you this form.

286 This fair complexion is not Mine: it comes from the touch of Rādhā’s body. And She touches no one but the son of the king of the cowherds.

287 Steeping My own mind in Her *bhāva*, I then taste My own sweetness.

288 Nothing I do is hidden from you. Even if I hide it, by the power of love you know every secret.

289 Keep it secret and reveal it to no one. People would laugh at My mad behavior.

290 I am one madman, and you are a second; therefore you and I are equals.”

291 In this way the Lord spent ten nights happily with Rāmānanda in the joy of talks about Kṛṣṇa.

292 They spoke at length on the deeply hidden pastimes of *rasa* in Vraja, yet never reached their end.

293 Suppose someone finds copper, bell-metal, silver, gold and the *cintāmaṇi* jewel buried together in one place.

294 Digging it up step by step, he comes upon ever finer treasure. In just this way the Lord and Rāma Rāya went from question to answer.

295 The next day the Lord asked Rāya's leave to go, and at the time of parting He gave him this instruction:

296 "Give up worldly affairs and go to Nīlācala. I shall visit the holy places and come there before long.

297 The two of us shall live together in Nīlācala and happily pass our time in the joy of talks about Kṛṣṇa."

298 Saying this, He embraced Rāmānanda, sent him home and lay down to rest.

299 Rising in the morning, the Lord had *darśana* of Hanumān, offered him obeisances and set out for the south.

300 All the people of Vidyāpura, whatever their doctrines, became Vaiṣṇavas on seeing the Lord and gave up their own views.

301 Rāmānanda was overwhelmed by separation from the Lord. Giving up all worldly affairs, he remained absorbed in meditation on Him.

302 I have told briefly of the Lord's meeting with Rāmānanda. Even the thousand-mouthed Ananta could not describe it in full.

303 Caitanya's life is by nature a flood of thickened milk, and Rāmānanda's life is the abundant sugar candy in it.

304 The pastimes of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa are the camphor mixed into it. Whoever is fortunate tastes it.

305 Whoever drinks it even once through the ears — his ears, out of longing, can never give it up.

306 By hearing it one gains knowledge of the truth of *rasa*, and loving devotion (*prema-bhakti*) awakens for the feet of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa.

307 From this one comes to know the hidden truth of Caitanya. Hear it with faith, and do not argue in your mind.

308 This pastime is beyond the world and supremely hidden. It is attained by faith; by argument it remains far away.

309 This treasure comes to one whose all in all is the feet of Śrī Caitanya, Nityānanda and Advaita.

310 To Rāmānanda Rāya I offer ten million obeisances. Through his mouth the Lord unfolded the truth of *rasa*.

311 Following the notes (*kaḍacā*) of Svarūpa Dāmodara, I have made known the pastime of the Lord's meeting with Rāmānanda.

312 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.